Lecture 29 — Same mathematics, very different computational cost

Fri Oct 30

Last updated: October 8, 2026.

Boyd video (optional): Lecture 6 — complexity · ENGR108 playlist (Boyd)

Textbook: Boyd & Vandenberghe, *VMLS* (PDF)

Reading: Boyd's $ab^\mathsf{T}c$ example. Related objectives: Lectures. Schedule.

Same mathematical answer can mean different storage and runtime depending on order — useful later for the capstone.

Same day: Quiz 8 (Week 9 dynamics — **not** today's cost lecture) and Lab 3.

Bring paper. After the quiz: short lecture (warm-up → fill-in → board → Your turn), then Lab 3.

Learning objectives

By the end of class, you should be able to:

1. Compare algebraically equivalent orders of computation.
2. Count intermediate values that must be stored.
3. Measure runtime for increasing problem sizes.
4. Explain why forming a large intermediate matrix may be wasteful.
5. Choose a computational order and justify it quantitatively.

Warm-up

Let $a = (1, 2)$, $b = (3, 4)$, $c = (1, -1)$ (column vectors).

(a) Form the outer product ab^T (a 2×2 matrix).

(b) Compute $(ab^\mathsf{T})c$ and $a(b^\mathsf{T}c)$. Same vector?

Fill in

Associativity. For compatible sizes, $(XY)z = X(Yz)$. In particular, for n-vectors a, b, c,

$$(ab^\mathsf{T})c = a(b^\mathsf{T}c).$$

Same mathematical result — different _____.

Order 1 — form the matrix first. Compute $M = ab^\mathsf{T}$ ($n \times n$), then Mc.

- Intermediate storage: about _____ numbers (the whole matrix M).
- Cost idea: building M and multiplying by c scales like _____ work (order n^2).

Order 2 — scalar first. Compute $s = b^\mathsf{T} c$ (one number), then sa.

- Intermediate storage: the scalar s, plus the vectors — order _____ numbers, not n^2.
- Cost idea: two inner/scale passes — order _____ work.

Why wasteful? Forming ab^T materializes a dense $n \times n$ matrix you may never need as an object; then you immediately collapse it with c. Capstone theme: choose an algorithm that matches the structure, not only the formula on the page.

Runtime. In software you can time both orders for growing n and justify which order to use with measured times (and storage counts).

Worked in class

W1. Algebra. With $a = (2, 0, -1)$, $b = (1, 1, 1)$, $c = (1, 0, 1)$, compute $s = b^\mathsf{T} c$ and $a(b^\mathsf{T} c)$. Then form ab^T and $(ab^\mathsf{T})c$. Match?

W2. Storage count. For general n, how many entries does ab^T have? How many numbers do you store for the scalar-first method beyond the three input vectors?

W3. Choose an order. You need $y = (ab^\mathsf{T})c$ for $n = 5000$ once. Which order do you run, and what two quantitative reasons (storage + flops/runtime idea) support the choice?

W4 (preview). Sketch what a timing table should look like: rows $n = 200, 1000, 3000$; columns "form ab^T then multiply" vs "scalar first." What qualitative pattern do you expect?

Your turn

Y1. Let $a = (1, -1, 0)$, $b = (2, 1, 3)$, $c = (0, 1, 1)$. Compute both $(ab^\mathsf{T})c$ and $a(b^\mathsf{T}c)$.

Y2. For $n = 100$, about how many intermediate entries does Order 1 store in ab^T? Order 2 in the scalar s?

Y3. One sentence: why can two algebraically equal expressions have wildly different runtimes?

Lab 3, same day

After this short lecture: Lab 3 — Mixing and Balancing. Write a small system, solve in software, check the residual, and prefer a solver over an explicit inverse. Preview the one-pager; write on the hard copy in class.

Answers (Your turn)

Y1. $b^\mathsf{T}c = 2 \cdot 0 + 1 \cdot 1 + 3 \cdot 1 = 4$, so $a(b^\mathsf{T}c) = 4a = (4, -4, 0)$. The matrix route gives the same:

$$ab^\mathsf{T} = \begin{bmatrix} 2 & 1 & 3 \\ -2 & -1 & -3 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}, \qquad (ab^\mathsf{T})c = (4, -4, 0).$$

Y2. Order 1 stores $n^2 = 10{,}000$ entries in ab^T. Order 2 stores one scalar s as the essential intermediate (beyond the inputs).

Y3. Associativity preserves the value but not the work: different parenthesizations create different intermediates (e.g. an $n \times n$ matrix vs a scalar), so flops and memory — and therefore runtime — can differ by orders of magnitude.